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vitamins and selenium. It also contains vitamins needed for human diet.

Land management: Grazing of livestock is sometimes used as a way to control weeds and undergrowth.

Manure: Manure can be spread on agriculture fields to increase crop yields.

Poultry Farming

The word poultry refers to the rearing and propagation of avian species such as chicken, ducks, turkeys, geese, quail and guinea fowls. The most common and commercially farmed birds are chicken and ducks. Poultry farming is essential for the purpose of meat, eggs and feather production. Commercial poultry farming is also profitable. In this part we are discussing about an overview of the chicken and duck breeds, farming practices and its advantages.

Types of Chicken breeds: There are more than 100 breeds. The commonly farmed chicken breeds are categorized into five based on the purpose for which it is farmed. They are egg layers, broiler type, dual type, games and ornamental types (Figure 13.14).

1. **Egg layers:** These are farmed mainly for the production of egg.

Leghorn: This is the most popular commercial breed in India and originated from Italy. They are small, compact with a single comb and wattles with white, brown or black colour. They mature early and begin to lay eggs at the age of 5 or 6 months. Hence these are preferred in commercial farms. They can also thrive well in dry areas.

Chittagong: It is the breed chiefly found in West Bengal. They are golden or light yellow coloured. The beak is long and yellow in colour. Ear lobes and wattles are small and red in colour. They are good egg layers and are delicious.

2. **Broiler type:** These are well known for fast growth and soft quality meat.

White Plymouth rock: They have white plumage throughout the body. It is commonly used in broiler production. This is an American breed. It is a fast growing breed and well suitable for growing intensively in confined farms.

3. **Dual purpose breeds:** These are for both meat and egg production purpose.

Brahma: It is a breed popularly known for its massive body having heavy bones, well feathered and proportionate body. Pea comb is one of the important breed characters. It has two common varieties namely, Light Brahma and Dark Brahma.

4. **Game breeds:** Since ancient times, special breed of roosters have been used for the sport of cockfighting.

Aseel: This breed is white or black in colour. The hens are not good egg layers but are good in incubation of eggs. It is found in all states of India. Aseel is noted for its pugnacity, high stamina, and majestic gait and dogged fighting qualities. Although poor in productivity, this breed is well-known for their meat qualities.

5. **Ornamental breeds:** Ornamental chicken are reared as pets in addition to their use for egg production and meat.

Silkie: It is a breed of chicken has a typical fluffy plumage, which is said to feel like silk and satin. The breed has